being thwarted again, this time by one of his own. And yet, to suggest that Advani's rebellion was occasioned purely by envy towards Modi would be unfair to a leader who has devoted a lifetime to the party. Yes, he still felt he deserved to be prime minister, but Advani was also an instinctive democrat, someone who had vigorously opposed the Emergency in 1975. Perhaps he saw shades of an autocratic Indira in Modi's behaviour and was looking to warn the party of the negative consequences.

But the party he had once so effectively piloted now had little time for the tantrums or advice of the ageing neta. The new leadership represented by the Modi–Rajnath–Jaitley troika was in no mood to bend. Even the RSS, which had once been fiercely aligned to Advani, had now seen the writing on the wall.

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The RSS has been often described as an extra-constitutional authority that lies at the apex of the Sangh Parivar, a 'brotherhood in saffron'. The RSS claims it is apolitical, that it only acts as an ideological guide to the BJP. The relationship between the RSS and the BJP, though, is often more intricate—the two are umbilically tied by their shared notion of cultural nationalism, and a cadre and leadership that work in close collaboration. The dual membership of the RSS and BJP (or Jan Sangh, as it was known then) had even contributed to the collapse of the non-Congress Janata Party government in the 1970s. The RSS may not be the BJP's daily remote control, as its critics suggest, but neither is it some voluntary organization solely devoted to social welfare. It is, at the end of the day, the final word within the saffron 'family'—the paterfamilias who has veto rights in the event of any internal dispute. In the build-up to the 2014 elections, the RSS had made its decision—Narendra Modi would be the BJP's prime ministerial candidate.

The backstory to the RSS's involvement in the 'Modi for PM' campaign began in the aftermath of the 2009 election debacle. If the 2004 election verdict had stunned the Sangh Parivar because of the surprise element, the